

site, another to display the latest e-mails, yet another might visually show the phases of the moon, while one might be used to track and show ticker prices on stocks. These Gadgets can reside on the Sidebar or as free-floating elements on the Desktop. The Sidebar itself can be placed at various places around the Desktop; it is even multi-monitor aware and can be placed on a second monitor if real-estate is prime on your primary display. All in all, the Windows Sidebar is a nice addition to the operating system; however the addition of Yet Another Widgetised Sidebar seems unnecessary in the light of similar options from Yahoo!, Google, Stardock, Desktop Sidebar, et al. Longhorn might have been the first to showcase the concept, but the road to Vista has been so long, the Windows Sidebar seems to have been too late to arrive.



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However, it should be noted that integration of a feature into an OS is in no way comparable to an external, third-party tool: the Windows Sidebar will boost the development of widgets at best, and will encourage already-developed widgets to be migrated as Gadgets, at worst. Stardock, for example, has already made public its intention of leveraging its current Widget inventory and know-how to make Gadget creation and porting easier.

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